up against five big challenges today, but the party has two major advantages as it navigates these problems.

Challenge 1: The Coronavirus Fallout and the Economy

The BJP's first big political challenge, going forward, is the long-term fallout of the second wave of the coronavirus which engulfed India in early-2021. Painful memories of loss or illness in virtually every family, oxygen shortages in many parts of the country, images of dead bodies floating in the Ganga and concerns over adequate vaccination availability at the time raised serious questions for the party, the Union government and state governments across India. Although Narendra Modi remained India's most popular political leader by far even in August 2021, the devastation caused by the pandemic was a major reason why *India Today's* bi-annual 'Mood of the Nation' survey showed a big dip in his ratings, compared to the same period the previous year. When asked how they rated Modi's performance as prime minister, 54 per cent Indians rated it as 'good' or 'outstanding' in August 2021—down from 74 per cent in January 2021 and 78 per cent in August 2020. When asked who they thought was best suited to be India's next prime minister, 24 per cent still said Modi. In comparison, the highest rated opposition leader on this question was Rahul Gandhi, at 10 per cent. However, Modi's rating on this very question had fallen from 38 per cent in January 2021 and 66 per cent in August 2020.[38] As the magazine's editorial director, Raj Chengappa, summed up, 'For Prime Minister Narendra Modi', the message coming out from this survey was clear: Indians were 'unhappy with the Centre's performance over the past six months' though they still 'saw the Modi government as the best bet' at the time.[39]

Conscious of the discontent caused by the pandemic, Modi undertook three major moves. First, he hit the 'reset' button in his government with major changes to his ministerial team on 8 July 2021. He brought into his government a new set of leaders in key roles, with thirty-six fresh faces. These included a new health minister, Mansukh Mandaviya from Gujarat's Bhavnagar, who was also given dual charge of chemicals and fertilizers (which includes